Where US Tech Firms Can Lease Smart: Availability, Affordability, and Flexibility in the Post-Covid World

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Problem

COVID-19 has changed the way people work. Many companies have transitioned to remote-only or hybrid work. Furthermore, with a worsening climate crisis, businesses are expected to handle the cost of additional disruptions to their business.

How can business minimize the cost and cope with the effects of more frequent natural disasters?

Our team approached this in two ways:

1. Identify U.S. office markets in the tech industry that have shown to be most suited to hybrid/remote work

- The tech industry leaded in remote and hybrid work
- Rank markets with a "flexible office leasing" value

2. Cater recommendations by business size

- Larger businesses will require higher office square footage

Map of Top Tech Post-COVID Flexible Office Markets

Why "Tech Industry"?

Tech Companies are the most innovational ones that have dynamic space needs and the highest remote adoption.
It went remote the earliest during COVID-19.

What does " flexible" mean in this context?

"Flexible" means that the lease agreement isn’t completely rigid. Instead of being locked into a set, unchanging amount of space over a long period, a flexible lease can include options that allow a company to adjust how much space it uses as its needs change. This might mean:

Option to Downsize → Ability to sublease unused space & Flexible reduction in space use

Option to Expand → Scalable space for growth & Capacity to add headcount onsite

Shorter Lease Terms → Short contracts or flexible renewals let companies reassess space needs regularly.

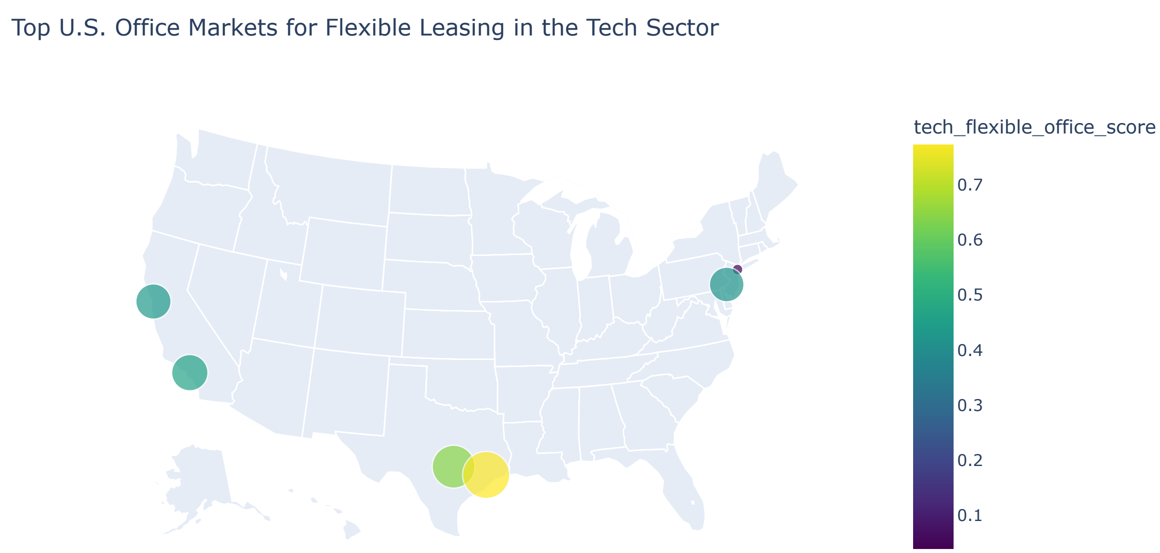
In short, "flexible" means that the company has room to adapt its office space usage over time—helping it manage costs and space effectively, even in a hybrid work setup

Metric	What It Tells Us	Impact on Flexibility Score
sublet_availability_prop	% of space availble for sublease	⬆️ Higher: More flexible options
availability_prop	Overall space available in the market	⬆️ Higher: Easier to lease space
avg_occupancy_prop	% of the building currently in use	⬆️ Higher: Signals demand and active usage
overall_rent	Avg rent ($/sqft)	⬇️ Lower: More cost-effective

What determines HIGH Flexibility Score?

Map of Leading Tech Office Markets by Space Flexibility

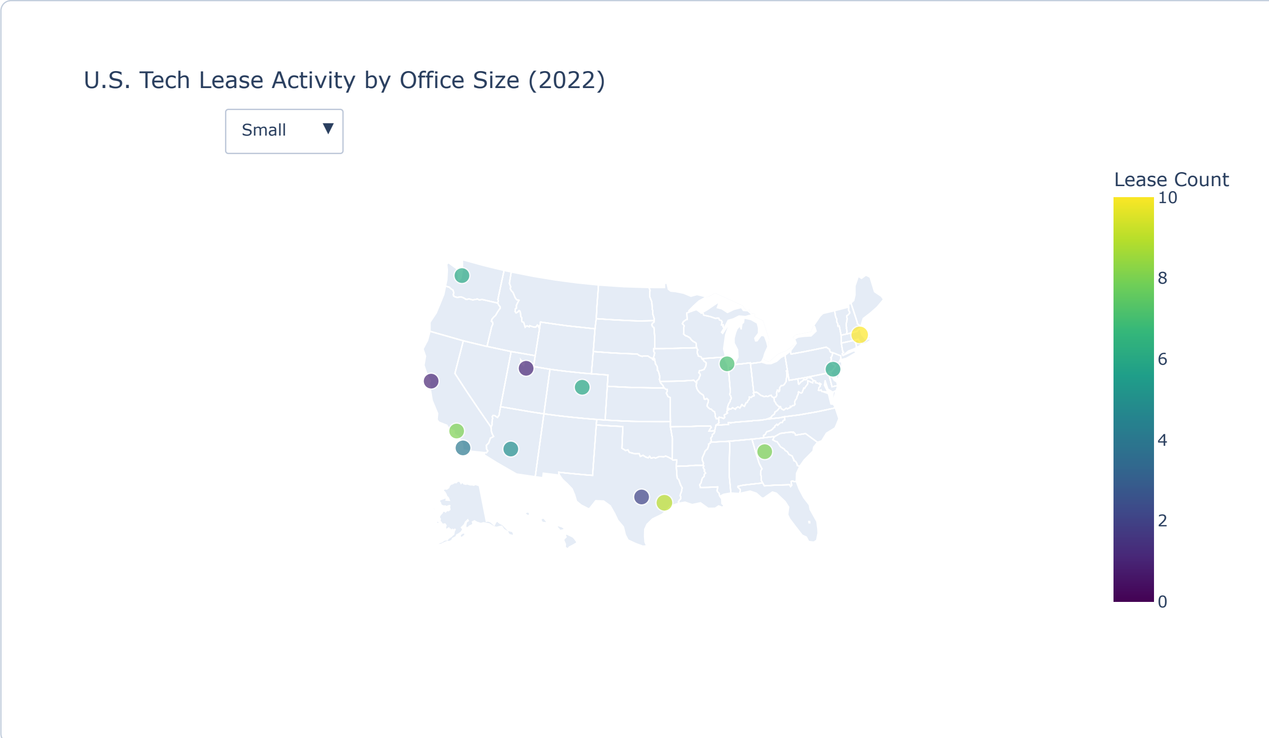
These cities offer the most leasing agility based on the 4 available metrics we chose!



Plenty of Office Space Available
Cities like **Houston** and **Austin** offer a surplus of available office space. This abundance gives tech companies the flexibility to find spaces that fit their needs, whether they're growing quickly or fully adapting to hybrid work setups.

Affordable Rents
Markets like **Austin** and provide lower rental costs compared to **traditional costal tech hubs** like San Francisco or New York. This affordability allows companies to save money, which is especially valuable as hybrid work reduces the need for full-time office attendance.

Flexible Sublease Options
Subleasing is a growing trend in cities like San Francisco and Austin, where tech companies can lease high-quality spaces without long-term commitments. Subleases often come with ready-to-use layouts designed for hybrid work, making it easier for companies to move in quickly and adjust as needed



What is this map telling us?

This map shows us:

Which cities tech startups, scaleups, and enterprises prefer to Lease Office Space based on affordability, availability, and flexibility

What can we take away from this?

We aimed to highlight how the size of a company affects the qualities it looks for in its office spaces

Scaleups → Need mid-term leases with room to grow

Startups → Cost-sensitive, favor sublets and flexible terms

Enterprises → Value stability, but now reassessing footprint

Disclaimer:

This 48-hour DataFest study offers preliminary insights and is not meant to replace long-term strategic leasing decisions or formal consulting.